# ROASTED SMASHED BABY POTATOES
## WITH WILD GREENS PESTO

serves 4

In the Southwest and some areas of the Great Basin, there is a variety of wild potato (*Solanum jamesii*) known as the Four Corners potatoes. Some Indigenous peoples in the region have long gathered or cultivated the tiny tuber, while others are reintroducing this traditional food to their gardens and diets today.

Unlike the common potato (*Solanum tuberosum*), the Four Corners potato is frost and drought tolerant—perfect for the cold desert climate of the region. They are harvested when they are small (from about the size of marbles up to 1 inch large). While packed with nutrients, they can also have a significant amount of glycoalkaloids. These naturally occurring plant compounds help protect a plant from pests and are found in most nightshades, including tomatoes, peppers, and potatoes. While generally harmless to humans at low levels, too much of them can cause gastrointestinal upset or other adverse symptoms.

At this moment, it's challenging to find Four Corners potatoes commercially or even to grow. If you're lucky enough to gather some, treat them like any other wild food and eat a small amount first before consuming more. If a tuber is especially sour or bitter, it's best not to eat it.

Perhaps, over time, this variety will become more domesticated, with more consistently lower glycoalkaloid levels, and a popular regional food plant. Inspired by this Indigenous potato, though, I created this recipe, which features crisp-edged potatoes flavored with a pesto of garlic, pinyon pine nuts, and wild greens. Use the smallest potatoes you can find.

- 1½ pounds Four Corners potatoes or baby potatoes, scrubbed well
- Sea salt
- Sunflower oil, for the pan and drizzling

WILD GREENS PESTO

- 2 tablespoons pinyon pine nuts (see page 324) or other pine nuts
- 2 cups packed wild greens, such as lamb's quarters, common plantain, watercress, or wild mustard
- 1 bulb and greens from wild garlic or 1 small garlic clove
- ½ cup sunflower oil
- Sea salt
- 1 tablespoon cider vinegar

Preheat the oven to 450°F.

In a large saucepan, combine the potatoes with water to cover by 1 inch and season with salt. Bring to a boil over high heat, then reduce the heat to medium-low and cook for 10 to 20 minutes, just until fork-tender.

Drain the potatoes and return them to the pot. Set them over low heat for a minute or two, just to dry them.

Grease a sheet pan with oil and set it in the oven for 1 minute. Pull it out just long enough to add the cooked potatoes and use the bottom of a mug to lightly crush each one. Drizzle them with oil and season with salt.

Roast for 15 to 30 minutes, until the potatoes are golden brown and crisp at the edges.

**Meanwhile, make the pesto:** In a small dry skillet, toast the pinyon pine nuts over medium heat for about 2 minutes, or until golden with a few browned spots. Transfer to a food processor to cool.

Add the greens and garlic and pulse to chop. With the machine running, add the oil until incorporated and the pesto is finely chopped. Season with salt. Transfer to a bowl. Just before serving, stir the vinegar into the pesto. Serve the potatoes with the pesto.